Kennedy's Children (Wanda)

By Robert Patrick

WANDA: For me, it was the most important day of my life. I measure everything as happening before it, or after it. I remember every detail, every instant, every little bit of information as it came in.

INTRODUCTION

The Presidential motorcade is approaching now – the cheers are growing nearer. It's a beautiful day here in Dallas, despite a light rain, and the people have turned out by the thousands to welcome their leader. President Kennedy's political enemies warned that there would be hostilities and riots, but listen to those cheers! Yes, there is the motorcade, and there's the President's car; we can tell because you can see Mrs. Kennedy's pink dress. They've left the bubbletop off the limousine in spite of the rain, so they can see the people, and the people can see them, and they love them! . . . . Then gunshots . . . . . Kennedy's Children by Robert Patrick.

WANDA: I was - at my desk. It was - lunchtime. The executives had gone out. I was in a hurry to finish page — 44! - of the - May-June issue of 'Salon Hair Styles.' Oh, not that I wrote it or edited it or anything. I just pasted the captions to the photos before they sent it out to the press. It *was* an exacting job though; I had to be very neat. One time I smeared some glue, and when we got the covers back for the January-February issue, the model on the cover looked like she had a runny nose. But, anyway, I was pasting up these photos, and the Fashions Editor kept interrupting me to show me her real Chanel suit from Paris-and I had to pretend to be interested because she drank something awful - I didn't drink in those days - and she was lifting up her skirt to show me how the hemline was kept in place with little chains sewn into the hem-and all I

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was really thinking about was my raspberry yogurt in the cooler section of the water fountain-and I had just had this horrible affair with this fellow who worked in the stockroom-and he hadn't shown up for four days -I was feeling really awful. *(She looks out the window at the rain.)* And I remember, it was a grey, grey day here in New York. And then-all of a sudden-all of a sudden Mr. Kanowsky, the Advertising Sales Manager. came bursting in! He was a little cross-eyed and always looked crazy. Anyway, he came bursting in, red-faced and excited, and he said, "Quick! Turn the radio on! The President's been shot in Dallas!"

Well, none of us believed it. I mean, none of us could conceive it. We just sat looking at him, and I guess we thought he was drunk or having palpitations-he was awful fat--and he said "Did you hear me? Turn on the radio!" So Carrie, the Accounts Payable lady, said, "Now cool it, Mr. Kanowsky, I'll turn the radio on," and he got a little frantic and said terrible things to her, and the Fashions Editor said a couple of unpleasant things to. him, and they were squabbling with each other right across me, and then Carrie's radio started up and the newscaster was saying-oh, I want to get this just right-saying, " ... reported that three Negroes were seen running from the overpass and two rifles have been confiscated in the immediate area," and how the President was going to be all right because they got him right to the hospital, and the Dallas Police were throwing a cordon around the entire area. And then suddenly we couldn't hear any more, because outside it seemed that every auto horn in the city had started blowing, and there was even a crash like somebody had driven right off the street onto the sidewalk, and the phones in the office began to ring-everyone of them, all at once, instantly, began to ring!

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We all stayed at the office for the whole rest of the day, right into evening, with nobody working except Carrie, who didn't have any relatives. The minute you'd hang a phone up, it would ring again, and everybody who called was listening to a different station, and getting a different version, and people from other offices would pop in and tell us what they'd just heard and one man, a middle-aged, respectable man who ran the *yachting* magazine in the next office, came in bawling, just crying like a baby, crying, "Oh, my God, it's a Communist plot, it's the end of the world!" And the news kept coming in, and you'd get one picture of the whole situation straight in your mind, and then all of a sudden there would be this new piece of information and it would all change, and somebody would break down crying, and they couldn't find the Vice- President-they thought all the politicians were going to be assassinated and I don't know *what* all. And then, at last, very quickly afterwards, not an hour, I think, although it seemed so much longer, they said the President was out of danger and everything was okay. And then the bells starts ringing, every church bell in New York started ringing, and we knew that he was dead. *(She rises, goes to bar for a refill. After a pause.)* I was the first one to say it. I was washing Lena, the Accounts Receivable girl's face, because she was crying and had smudged ink all over her face, so I was right by her phone when it rang, and I picked her phone up, and it was my mother, saying, "Wanda, come home! He's going to be all right! They just said so!" And the Fashions Editor fell out of her office with this big drunken smile on her face and a bottle in one hand, yelling, "J.F.K.'s gonna pull through!" And *that's* when the bells started ringing. And none of them were Catholic, so they didn't know what it meant, and they were all smiling and grinning like fools, and I said, "He's dead. The President is dead. God rest his soul." *(Returns to her table.)*

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Within a few hours – do you remember this? -within a few hours one of the major magazines had a special edition out on the newsstands, and of course, within a few days they all did. Mr. Kanowsky ran around and bought everything, every paper, every magazine, he tape-recorded the radio stations, he even ran down-as soon as they announced the President was dead-he ran down and bought a color TV set-just ran down and came right back up carrying it. Puffing and red-faced. And we all watched-but it was all just chaos. Mr. Kanowsky has it all in scrapbooks, everything, all the rumors and confusions, and then all the-you know-Oswald stuff-and all the conflicting reports-and he was even taping from the TV later he didn't go home for three days-he was even taping the TV soundtrack-when Ruby-did that awful thing. When he sealed the truth off from us forever by firing a single shot--the lips of the one man who might have told us all about it, closed forever by one single little bullet shot . . . or was it two?

I couldn't go on working in that kind of job any more, after it happened. I remember the next night, walking along Broadway, and how weird it was to see the theatres all closed-and all these hundreds of color photographs of J.F.K. in the store windows. Somebody must have made a fortune selling those photographs because they were everywhere instantly or maybe people had had them all along and you just didn't notice them. It was like-like the sun had begun to eclipse. Everyone was scared of a chain of assassinations, or a war, but by the next day, nobody was afraid any more. That had passed, and it had become just--disbelief. In Saint Patrick's cathedral-or outside it, I never got in, the crowds were so big - hundreds of thousands of people were saying

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prayers for him. The whole world had loved him, you see, so much. The entire human race went into mourning. Kings and queens came to his funeral. All the TV channels had the same things on for four whole days. They even gave us the day off to watch.

It's ridiculous to talk about an event like that from the point of view of somebody like me. I mean, what difference does it make in the long run how I felt about it? I used my savings to finish another year at CCNY-that's City College of New York enough so that now I have my temporary teaching certificate and can work as a substitute teacher. I just thought-if all of us who believed in him don't go out and try to do some good, then his death was completely-completely in vain. Oh, of course I'm not comparing my little contribution to what he might have done if he had lived. If he had lived, he would have stopped the war. If he had lived, he would have solved the race problem. If he had lived, he would have found some way to bring us all together. I know that there are people who are cynical who say he didn't accomplish much in those-"Thousand Days"-but I always say to people like that, I say *(With mounting anger.)* "Oh, yes? Yes? Yes? Oh, yes? And exactly what have you accomplished?

Looking back to the first time I heard about him-and her-I remember that they had found a way of life we could all imitate. He worked so hard. He was inspiring, encouraging, and of course, so handsome and young - young for a President. And she . . . Well, I was always very fond of her, too. I don't look well, dressed the way she dressed, and I think maybe she let their publicity people-they had their own publicity people, you know-I think maybe she did let those advisors talk her into looking, well, maybe a little less distinguished than

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she might have looked. The Fashions Editor used to say, before it happened and even afterwards-she'd look at pictures of Jackie and she'd say, "She looks like a collage of Doris Day's wardrobe, Elizabeth Taylor's makeup, and Natalie Wood's hairdo." I don't think that was kind. I'm sure if she had been a private person, Jackie would have dressed with more restraint and taste. But after all, she was our ambassadrix to the world and I suppose she had to dress in a way that would appeal to people in the mass.

When they were alive - I mean when she was alive-when *he* was alive, you could never resist reading about them. He could read a half-dozen books a day, and he had been a war hero. And, you know, it was him that popularized the James Bond books. It's true. They weren't that popular at all until he mentioned to a reporter that he liked them and then, well, do you remember how suddenly everyone was reading James Bond? And she was very responsible for starting a certain "look" among young women. Politician's wives since her have all *tried* to dress nicely. And, oh, do you remember that record, "The First Family?" That was so popular. It had all sorts of jokes-good natured jokes, really-about him and her and his brothers and just everybody. Drugstores and supermarkets had stacks of it beside their cash-registers. And he wrote books, too, and one of them won the Pulitzer Prize, really, when he was still just a Senator. And she, when she was still a student, won the Vogue Magazine Prix de Paris for her article on "My Favorite Artists I Would Most. Like' To Have Known From The Past." They were remarkable people! Everything they touched turned to gold!

He was from a wealthy family, of course, but they had made their money

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themselves, and they were still, you know, rough, charming, brawling Irishmen, whereas she was from very "old money" as they call it, and she would have been a career girl, a photographer, if they hadn't met. They were so happy. They loved that musical "Camelot," the story of a distant, beautiful, forgotten kingdom where there was always sunshine and justice. Camelot. "Don't let it be forgot, That once there was a spot, For one brief shining moment, That was known as Camelot." Camelot. I think maybe we all had a glimpse of Camelot—once just once-in our own lifetime-before it crumbled.

They made "Camelot" into a movie, but it wasn't really very-I mean, it was just a medieval pageant, it didn't have the tenderness and the beauty and the sense of-you know-something that could really happen. And it was-you know-very sexy really dirty, for a musical. I didn't watch the second half at all. People don't seem to-I would have thought there would have been a lot of letters in the newspapers about it-about them messing up the President's favorite musical. But there weren't. I guess people had forgotten *little* things like that. In fact-when you walk down on Orchard Street, the pushcart street down in the Village where you can buy a lot of things cheap? Well, one time I was down there after some movie actress died-I don't even remember her name, although my mother was quire broken up about it-and they had replaced all the pictures of him with pictures of her. It was-horrible. You know how stores have the pictures in the frames they're trying to sell? I mean it's the frames they're trying to sell, not the pictures? Well, instead of having him in the frames, or even him and Bobby Kennedy and Martin Luther King-they had these pin-up photos of the girl who had just died.

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Just because-well, not for any *reason!* Just because she had *died!* I mean people seem to remember, they seem to care, but they seem to have gotten things all mixed up

You hear stories now-and I don't mean just the stories about how it wasn't really Oswald who killed him, but it was really Johnson, or it was really Nixon, or Cubans, or oil millionaires, or Communists, or Ruby, or all of them together-or how the avantgarde threatre people put on all those awful parodies of Shakespeare-or how the sincere Shakespeare people in the park revived anything that had the killing of a king in it. I think some of those people mean well, but it sure is funny how they all do seem to be making a buck out of it-isn't it? No, I mean that you hear stories that make you wonder just how well people remember. I mean stories like-that Jackie was paid a million dollars to stay with him because they really hated each other. Or that they were both homosexual. Or that he had a movie-actress mistress. Or that he was in the pay of big industry, or-things that nobody could know, anyway, even if they were true. And you wonder: why do people even want to speculate about such things? When there's so much good to remember? When, above all, the beauty that never even got to happen is still there, waiting for us all to build! What right have they got to talk against her? How can they blame her for getting married again? My God, just to get away from all the people that try to make her into some kind of a pin-up girl, or clown! When she was there! Right there beside him! Closer than anybody in the world!

But there are some of us who still try-who still try to go on. My work-I'm going to have a full teaching license in just another three years-I'm work-

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ing with subnormal-what they *call* subnormal children, out in Jersey. It's very hard to try to help them into the world. They are of minorities, children whom the culture has forgotten, children of twelve who can't speak because they have never been spoken to in their homes, children who are afraid of things they can't even name, children without love or hope. Some of them may never be able to join the human race. But I can try. Today I mentioned to them something - something about him-and not one of them, not a single one of them, even knew who he was, It was, for a moment, as if he had never been. I tried to show them that famous *Life* magazine with the color photos of the-assassination-but it excited one of them too much, and two of the others just went crazy at the pictures of the blood-so, I wound up instead just telling them about Camelot. Without the sex stuff between Guinevere and Lancelot, of course. It's almost the same story. If I'd wanted to, I suppose I could even have told them the story of Christ, and it would have been almost the same story .

And yet, even after they understood the story, it was hard to make them see why it had all been so wonderful. There's no one like that now, they can't even imagine anyone like that, they're used to the idea that the world is just a swamp of violence and crooked politics and unexpected death and ugliness everywhere. They can't understand that there was time, a space of several years, when everyone loved someone, someone bigger and better than other people. They can't understand that all the people-everyone in the world-loved him. All. But one.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Robert Patrick
ISBN: 978-0573611261
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 1998

AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier

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